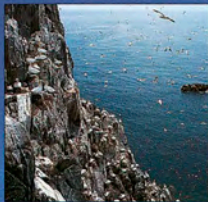


SEABIRDS



Playful puffins and graceful gannets, like most seabirds, feed, preen, and sleep out on the sea for most of the year. But each summer they come ashore to lay their eggs. Most nest in huge groups, called colonies.

Their families are safer with thousands of pairs of eyes watching for danger. Some seabirds choose to crowd onto steep cliffs, well out of the reach of many egg thieves.

These long wings catch the breeze and lift the herring gull up in the air like a kite.

Herring gull chicks peck at this red spot to make their parents cough up food.

Some seabirds spend most of their lives in the air, so they don't often use their legs.

Waterproof feathers

Webbed feet

Dive, dive, dive!

When a gannet spots a shoal of fish, it folds up its wings and hurtles into the water. Less than 10 seconds later, having swallowed the fish under water, it is flying again.

Gannets dive from up to 150 feet (45 meters) into the sea and reach speeds of 60 mph (100 km/h).

A bony flap covers each nostril.

The hard skull protects the gannet like a crash helmet!

Seabirds do not get tired on long trips because they can glide for hours on end without flapping their wings.

This spear-shaped bill is ideal for catching fish.